direction of Bokhara and Afghanistan. They were carrying out a regular, scientific and comprehensive scheme of propaganda in Central Asia against the British. We ourselves had no military forces wherewith to oppose them; in fact, at the moment, our troops were at their lowest ebb...[23]

Whether the current success of the Red Army meant that the Soviet government would attempt an attack on Persia, however, was unclear. In the opinion of the Indian government, the real danger lay in Bolshevik emissaries and propaganda infiltrating Persia, rather than military action.[24] (In January 1920 the first 'Red Train' left Moscow for Turkestan, laden with propaganda materials.)[25]

The question remained, however, as to whether Persia was actually worth saving from a Bolshevik military attack if it came to it. For the Indian government, the answer was much the same in 1920 as it had always been: that Persia simply was not worth the cost, particularly if it meant using Indian resources. Indeed, Montagu had already let Curzon know that India could no longer be responsible for the cost of retaining Malleson and his force at Meshed. In the opinion of the secretary of state for India, any danger which Bolshevism posed to Persia was 'largely the fault of the Home Government in their anti-Mohemmedan policy'[26] and defending Persia was 'not an Indian matter'.[27] The refusal of the Indian government to provide more men for Persia was particularly important given the small number of British troops stationed in that country at the time. As the CIGS made clear, Britain could not save Persia in the face of a Bolshevik attack even if it wanted to. In which case, 'If His Majesty's Government has no intention of assisting Persia to defend her territory by the use of British troops, the logical course is for the North Persian Brigade to be withdrawn.'[28]

Nevertheless, in the early months of 1920, if the soldiers and diplomats did not always entirely agree on the course to be pursued in Persia, there was at least an understanding that the situation was complex. As the general staff explained: